

medication. The assisted living staff provides care as needed and not constantly like in the case of a caregiver.

5. **Continuing Care Retirement Communities (CCRC):**

Continuing Care Retirement Communities are the ideal option for seniors who would like to move into a comfortable living arrangement where they can settle down for the rest of their lives. These communities provide a staged approach to ageing with independent living, assisted living, and frail care all available in the same community. This allows seniors to get the increasing level of care they need over time without having to leave their friends and familiar environment they've enjoyed through the years. It's also a great option for couples who have different levels of care needs but want to remain living together.

CAREGIVER QUALIFICATIONS

Every Preferred Care at Home caregiver possesses two key qualifications: a compassionate heart and home care experience. The first and most significant caregiver qualification is the compassionate heart. No training can create this uncompromising, required quality. It's simply part of who the caregiver is. This is a mandatory prerequisite for every one of our caregivers. Becoming a professional caregiver requires specific skills, passion, and a commitment to serving clients cheerfully even when you are having a bad day.

Preferred Care at Home's caregivers also have the following qualities:

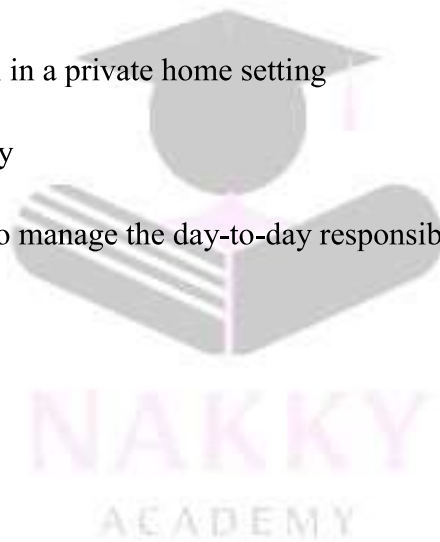
- Unselfishness. They put others first.
- A loving heart. They show unconditional, loving kindness.
- A cheerful heart.
- Commitment and flexibility.

- A respectful and supportive manner.
- An empathetic and patient spirit.
- Teachability.

In addition to these characteristics, caregivers must also be physically fit and in good health because of all the client lifting and transporting that they may be asked to do.

Experienced in-home caregivers also possess these skills:

- An understanding of different client needs
- The ability to function well in a private home setting
- A firm grasp of home safety
- An understanding of how to manage the day-to-day responsibilities of home.



1) **Assess medical needs:**

Checking on your senior loved one's health is an important caregiver responsibility. You may need to help keep track of medical appointments, manage medications and chronic conditions, or assess pain levels. It's a good idea to discuss your loved one's health with their doctor and other health professionals regularly.

2) **Prescription medication management:**

Since medications do fall under the umbrella of healthcare, it can be tempting to have the same person handle everything. As people age, however, their prescriptions can grow at an alarming pace. Some patients may take more than a dozen different meds at a time, and the sheer number of meds can bring about the need for one dedicated caregiver to oversee the prescribing, changes, administration and pick-up of orders. This caregiver should also regularly check on medication supply; since some pain prescriptions are a target for theft, controlled substances should be locked up and counted on a daily basis.

3) **Prepare a care plan:**

Preparing a care plan that addresses your senior loved one's care needs and goals can be helpful when you begin your caregiving journey. A plan can help you determine how many hours of care a day your loved one will require and whether you need additional help to ensure his or her health and safety.

4) **Help with personal hygiene and care:**

Memory and mobility issues can make even basic needs such as eating, bathing, grooming, and toileting — commonly referred to as “activities of daily living,” or ADLs — difficult. Check-in often and pay attention to specific signs and changes to determine if your loved one needs extra help.

5) **Provide companionship:**

One of the most essential but sometimes overlooked parts of caregiving is companionship. Feelings of loneliness in older adults can lead to serious health consequences including depression. When you care for an aging loved one, you are creating opportunities to strengthen your bond and connection.

6) **Help with housekeeping:**

As your loved one ages, maintaining a home can become increasingly difficult. Older adults may need help with dishes, taking out the garbage, or vacuuming. If your loved one lives in a house, yard work, snow shoveling, and daily maintenance may be too much for them to handle even with your help. Consider whether your loved one would benefit from the convenience and support of a senior living community.

7) **Assess your care plan regularly:**

As circumstances surrounding you and your loved one inevitably change, the care plan will need to be adjusted. Review it regularly to determine what's working, what's not, and what needs to be adapted. Keep in close contact with your loved one's doctor and other health professionals to discuss any changes.

8) **Prepare meals:**

Food preparation can become increasingly difficult with age. If your loved one lives alone, they may lack the energy or motivation to cook. In some cases, memory and balance issues may make cooking unsafe. As a caregiver, you can help with grocery shopping, preparing meals or finding alternatives to ensure your loved one gets proper nutrition.

9) **Assist with transfer and mobility:**

Falls are a major risk to the health of older adults. Your loved one may have difficulty moving or transferring — from their bed in the morning to a chair in the afternoon, for instance. As a caregiver, you can take steps to help prevent falls and help your loved one stay safe and comfortable.

10) Provide Transportation:

As people age, they may feel the urge to withdraw and avoid going out. A supportive caregiver provides some normalcy by driving them to social events, as well as their needed medical appointments. Whether it's to pick up books at the library or get them to a much-needed dental cleaning, having the means to get around as they need, and want, will help with providing a healthy quality of life for your loved one.

THE CAREGIVER-CLIENT RELATIONSHIP

The caregiver has a powerful role in the relationship between caregiver and client. This power comes from:

- 1) Control over the services provided to the client
- 2) Access to private knowledge about the client.

It's important not to let the balance of power slide heavily onto the caregiver's side of the relationship. Maintaining professional boundaries helps the caregiver maintain a helpful or "therapeutic" relationship with the client. A good question to ask yourself: Are my actions more about my needs than about the needs of my client? If so, you may be crossing a professional boundary.

To learn more about how to stay in the zone of helpfulness, let's explore the following chart. The chart gives examples of boundary crossings and offers tips for staying in bounds in specific situations.

TYPES OF BOUNDARY CROSSING	HOW TO STAY IN BOUNDS
Sharing Personal Information: It may be tempting to talk to your client about your personal life or problems. Doing so may cause the client to see you as a friend instead of seeing you as a health care professional. As a result, the	• Use caution when talking to a client about your personal life. • Do not share information because you need to talk, or to help you feel better.